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Memes, How Funny Are They Really?

When spending almost any length of time on the internet, whether scrolling social media or texting with friends, the odds are great that memes will make an appearance. They often play a part in online experiences both good and bad, potentially having a lasting impact. The responsibility and concerns that come with the creation and sharing of memes differs based on the capacity in which the creator or sharer is working; a professional in the workplace and a teenager at home will have different views and responsibilities to consider. However, no matter what someone does or the kinds of memes they like, there is a general responsibility and standards that one should be held to, especially from a Christian perspective.

One of the key aspects of what makes a good meme is that they are organic. Memes that are "manufactured" in nature cannot truly achieve what good memes do—bringing together communities of people over shared experiences or thoughts through humor and current media topics. These current media topics or sources of media that memes are built from often contain images or likenesses of people with or without their permission. When considering the question of whether permission should be sought out for meme creation it is best to consider things like the use of video or photos taken in public, assuming the image(s) used for the meme were obtained in a similar manner. In these cases, the assumption is that an individual is in public and thus gives up their right to privacy, allowing the video or photos to be freely used. I believe that similarly, images of individuals used for memes are acceptable to use without their express

permission if the photo was posted publicly online. If they do not want their likeness used, they should not put it on the internet. However, sometimes likenesses and images are personal content that was not intended to be put onto the internet. In these cases, I do believe that there should be options for legal recourse; however, once the meme is out there it is very likely that the damage is already done.

Aside from the privacy and permission considerations of meme creation and sharing, there is also a legal aspect to consider, especially considering that some memes are derogatory or even hate spreading in nature. Zechariah 7:10 says “do not oppress the widow, the fatherless, the sojourner, or the poor, and let none of you devise evil against another in your heart.” This Biblical advice is exactly how any Christians should view their responsibilities when creating or contemplating sharing a meme. If the meme is hurtful, untrue, or otherwise not done in love then it should not be made or shared. God calls us to look out for others, the fatherless, the poor, and to intentionally cause harm or make a joke at their expense is wrong. As for the general legality of it all, legally the lines between whether content like memes can lead to suing someone for slander seem to be a bit blurred. According to Forbes, “...statements that are widely distributed and preserved permanently are more likely to be viewed as libel while statements made to smaller audiences that are fleeting are more likely to be viewed as slander” and where memes fall on this spectrum is likely to vary, making a lawsuit a difficult and costly avenue to pursue.

Some may argue that because of the power and effect that a meme can have on a person's life there should be guidelines for their creation. In general, there already exist general “rules” that online communities adhere to, like picking on major corporations and not mom and pop shops and bringing awareness to issues in government and communities. However, as far as standardized and acknowledged guidelines for “home grown” memes I believe there should not

be. This is a bit different for those making and sharing memes in a professional capacity, in which case I believe making sure that memes are in line with ACM ethics guidelines is the safest route to take. As mentioned in their code of ethics, computing professionals have a responsibility to look out for the best of the public and to produce and promote things which benefit all, and that they seek to do no harm. If one is not willing to adhere to the moral guidelines of Christianity when creating memes, then they should at the very least consider guidelines like those provided by the ACM. Memes may seem insignificant or silly, but their effects can be profound and should be made and shared with careful consideration.

Works Cited

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